

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 21

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A firefighter recounts a rescue at a burning warehouse — the heat through the suit, a wrong turn into a collapsing corridor, and the long crawl to a window with a trapped worker on her back.

1

The first thing they do not tell you about a serious fire is how quiet it is on the inside. There is the low, continuous roar of the burn — a sound rather like a very large washing machine in another room — and the occasional sharp cough of something giving way overhead, but the human noises, the shouts and the radio chatter, are softened by the thick hood under the helmet, and by the strange, attentive calm that descends on a person at work. I went through the warehouse door at twelve minutes past two in the morning, and the world, for a little while, went very small.

2

The heat met me at once, even through the suit. People imagine, I think, that a fire suit makes you cool, the way a cold drink makes a hot afternoon manageable. It does not. It buys you time. Through it, the heat presses on every surface of your body at once, gentle and patient, like a hand that is not yet pushing but means to. I checked my air gauge, gave the wall a tap with the back of my glove, and began to count my paces inwards, because in a warehouse without windows there is no other way to know where you have been.

3

Training teaches you a great deal. It teaches you to keep one hand on the wall, to crouch low where the air is cooler, and to breathe in measured, unexcited mouthfuls. It teaches you to repeat to yourself, silently, the name of the person you are looking for, so that the name does not dissolve in the heat. Mr Chua. Mr Chua. A night watchman, sixty-one, last seen by colleagues near the rear loading bay. Training, however, cannot prepare you for the moment when, twenty paces in, you reach a fork in a corridor that was not on the floor plan, and you must choose.

4

I chose left. I had reasons that seemed good at the time — the air felt slightly cooler, the wall throbbed slightly less under my glove — but five paces later the ceiling above me made a noise I had not heard before, a low groan ending in a crack, and a section of it came down behind me in a hot rush of sparks and plaster. There was no going back the way I had come. I stood very still for perhaps three seconds. In training, three seconds is a long time. I thought about my daughter, who is nine, and who had drawn me a picture of a fire engine the previous week. Then I went on, because going on was what I had come to do.

5

I found Mr Chua in a small office at the end of the corridor, behind a desk he had crawled under. He was conscious, just. His hand, when I took it, was hot through my glove, but his grip was firm. He did not speak. People rarely do, at that moment; the body has too much else to attend to. I checked his airway, fitted the spare hood from my belt over his face, and lifted him into a fireman's carry across my shoulders. He was lighter than I had expected. Most people are.

6

The way out was not the way in. The corridor behind us had closed, and the smoke ahead had thickened into a brown wall through which my helmet lamp made only a faint, useless cone. I dropped to my knees and began to crawl. Crawling with a man on your back is not, despite what films suggest, a graceful motion. It is a slow, dragging shuffle, in which one shoulder takes the weight, the other steadies, and the knees do most of the talking. I counted aloud inside my mask. Eleven, twelve, thirteen. I needed the numbers to be louder than the roar.

7

At twenty-seven I felt, rather than saw, a difference in the air to my left — the faintest cool current, the merest hint of an outside world. I turned towards it. There was a high window, set above head height, its glass already starred from the heat. I struck it with the flat of my axe. It went all at once, in a soft tinkling rush, and the night came pouring through it like a held breath being let out. I shouted, and from somewhere below a voice — a familiar voice, my colleague Hafiz — shouted back. A ladder banged against the wall outside. Hands reached up.

8

Afterwards, sitting on the back step of the appliance with a foil blanket around my shoulders and a paper cup of sweet tea in both hands, I noticed that my own hands were shaking very gently, and that I was not surprised by this. Mr Chua, on a stretcher beside me, opened his eyes once. He did not say thank you. He looked at me for a long second and gave a single, considered nod. It was enough. It was, in fact, more than enough. The noise of the world — the radios, the engines, the shouted instructions — came rushing back, and I noticed, as if for the first time in hours, that I could hear.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says that “the world, for a little while, went very small.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about her experience as she entered the warehouse. [2]

2. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 1 that shows that, despite the danger, the narrator was **calm** as she went in. [1]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator compares the heat through her suit to “a hand that is not yet pushing but means to.” Explain how this image makes the heat feel **threatening**. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. Why does the narrator repeat the name “Mr Chua. Mr Chua.” inside her head? Answer in your own words. [2]

5. The narrator says that “training, however, cannot prepare you” for the moment she reaches the fork in the corridor. What does this suggest about the **difference** between training and a real emergency? [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator says, “I thought about my daughter, who is nine, and who had drawn me a picture of a fire engine the previous week.”

(a) Why do you think the writer includes this detail at this point in the story? [1]

(b) What does the narrator’s decision to “go on” immediately afterwards reveal about her character? [1]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator says of Mr Chua, “He was lighter than I had expected. Most people are.” Explain what is **unusual** about the second sentence, and what it suggests about the narrator’s experience of rescuing people. [2]

From Paragraph 6

8. The narrator describes crawling with a man on her back as “a slow, dragging shuffle, in which one shoulder takes the weight, the other steadies, and the knees do most of the talking.” Explain how the language used in this sentence makes the action feel **exhausting**. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 6. [3]

From Paragraph 7

9. The narrator describes the night air, when the window breaks, as coming “pouring through it like a held breath being let out.” Explain what is **effective** about this comparison. [2]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator says of Mr Chua’s nod, “It was enough. It was, in fact, more than enough.” What is the **effect** of repeating and then extending the phrase in this way? [1]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article weighing the arguments for and against compulsory voting in democratic societies.

1

Few political ideas divide reasonable people as cleanly as compulsory voting. To its supporters, it is the most sensible reform a democracy can make: a small civic obligation that ensures every adult voice is counted. To its critics, it is an offence against liberty — a state insisting, on pain of a fine, that citizens take part in a ritual whose meaning they may not share. The argument is old, but it has acquired new urgency. In an age when democracies fret about declining turnout, distrust, and unequal participation, the question of whether voting should be a duty as well as a right deserves another, careful look.

2

A handful of countries already enforce it. Australia, the most-cited example, has required eligible citizens to vote in federal elections since 1924. Those who fail to do so without a valid reason receive a polite but firm letter and a modest fine, currently twenty Australian dollars. Belgium has had compulsory voting since 1893, though its fines are rarely pursued. Singapore, less well known on this list, requires its citizens to vote at general and presidential elections, and removes from the electoral roll those who fail to do so without explanation, restoring their names only on application. In each of these countries, turnout regularly exceeds ninety per cent — a figure that voluntary systems can scarcely imagine.

3

The civic argument for compulsion is straightforward. A democracy, its defenders say, is a shared project; voting is the moment at which the project is renewed. If only the loudest and most motivated turn out, the result reflects them, not the country. By contrast, when everyone votes, the eventual government is, in a meaningful sense, the choice of the whole electorate. Mandatory voting also lifts the participation of groups that habitually vote less — the young, the poor, recent immigrants — and, in doing so, narrows the gap between the politically powerful and the politically forgotten. Several studies, including a long-running analysis by Australia's Electoral Commission, suggest that turnout equity, not just turnout, is what really shifts under compulsion.

4

The objections begin with liberty. Voting, the argument runs, is a right, and a right that one is forced to exercise has ceased to be a right and become a duty. To compel a citizen to vote is, in this view, no different in principle from compelling her to attend a particular place of worship, and the modest size of the fine does not alter the matter. A second, subtler objection concerns the **quality** of the vote. Critics worry that compulsion drags to the ballot box a great many people who would, left to themselves, happily stay at home — voters who know nothing of the candidates, vote essentially at random, or simply spoil their ballots in protest. A high turnout, in this view, may be a noisier signal but not necessarily a wiser one.

5

The supporters of compulsion have answers, of varying strength. To the liberty objection, they reply that democratic citizens already accept many small civic compulsions — jury service, tax filing, school attendance — and that voting, being the foundation on which all the others rest, is a particularly reasonable one. To the “uninformed voter” objection, they concede the point and then turn it: if compulsion brings in unreflective voters, the proper response is not to keep them at home but to invest more seriously in civic education and accessible information. A democracy, they argue, that fears its own electorate has already lost something important.

6

Compulsion, intriguingly, also changes the behaviour of politicians. Where turnout is voluntary and

unpredictable, campaigns concentrate on **mobilising the base** — getting committed supporters to the polls — and on attacking the opponent fiercely enough to depress turnout among his. Where everyone will vote anyway, those tactics lose much of their value. Campaigns must instead persuade the **median** voter, the broadly undecided citizen who would not, in a voluntary system, be there at all. Researchers comparing Australian and American federal campaigns have noted that Australian advertising tends to be markedly less negative, and that policy detail features more prominently. Whether this is a permanent feature of compulsion or merely a coincidence of culture remains debated; but the pattern is suggestive.

7

What, then, should a democracy do? The honest answer is that there is no single right answer; the choice depends on what a society most fears. A country that fears apathy and unequal voice may reasonably prefer compulsion. A country that fears the heavy hand of the state may reasonably prefer the right to abstain. What is harder to defend is the comfortable middle position: a voluntary system whose participation rates have fallen so low that the government in office can fairly be said to represent only a passionate minority. If we believe the vote matters, we must, sooner or later, decide what kind of effort we are willing to expect of those who hold it.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says compulsory voting “divides reasonable people as cleanly as” any political idea. What does this **opening claim** suggest about the writer’s view of the debate? [2]

13. According to Paragraph 1, give **two** concerns about modern democracies that have made the question of compulsory voting more urgent. [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. From Paragraph 2, give **one** way in which Singapore’s enforcement of compulsory voting **differs** from Australia’s. [1]

15. The writer says that turnout in compulsory-voting countries is “a figure that voluntary systems can scarcely imagine.” Explain, in your own words, what this means. [2]

From Paragraph 3

16. The writer says that compulsion “narrows the gap between the politically powerful and the politically forgotten.” Explain what is meant by the phrase **politically forgotten**. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer puts the word **quality** in italics in Paragraph 4. Why does he do this? [1]

18. The writer says that, in the critics’ view, “a high turnout... may be a noisier signal but not necessarily a wiser one.” Explain, in your own words, what this means. [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. In Paragraph 5, the writer says that “a democracy that fears its own electorate has already lost something important.” What is the writer’s **attitude** towards critics who use the “uninformed voter” objection? Justify your answer with reference to the paragraph. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. From Paragraph 6, identify **two** ways in which compulsory voting changes how political campaigns are run. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer says that “the comfortable middle position” is “harder to defend” than either of the alternatives. Explain, in your own words, why he thinks this. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the arguments in favour of compulsory voting** and **the objections raised against it**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 5** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Those who support compulsory voting argue that ...

— END OF PAPER —